



ASSEMBLY  
Elections 08



SHABNAM LONE  
(LEFT) AND  
BEGUM KHALIDA  
SHAH

## SISTERLY GRIT

Two Kashmiri ladies from the most prominent families are staking claim to their long-dead fathers' political legacies. The entry of Begum Khalida Shah, daughter of the legendary Sheikh Abdullah, and Shabnam Lone, daughter of slain separatist leader Abdul Ghani Lone, has enlivened an otherwise lacklustre poll scenario marked by the shadow of poll boycott by separatists. Shah's plans to fight against Farooq Abdullah has had the brother scurrying for cover, forcing him to change constituency. Shabnam fights on, defying the poll-boycott writ issued by her separatist brothers Sajjad and Bilal. Win or lose, they have shown grit.

by Ramesh Vinayak



## In Memory



A record number of kin of slain politicians are contesting the elections in Jammu and Kashmir, the separatists' writ notwithstanding. The trend is more pronounced in the Valley where as many as 18 blood relatives of the slain are in the fray. Past elections have shown that the sympathy factor works, which explains why all mainstream parties have been liberally doling out tickets to sons and daughters. Among them is **Shilpi Verma**, a BJP candidate who is the widow of Kuldeep Verma, who committed suicide in August in protest over the Amarnath Shrine standoff.

by Ramesh Vinayak



PANJAB BHAWAR

## No No Minister

Yuvraj he may be, but Tukoji Rao Paur, the Madhya Pradesh minister couldn't escape jail for misbehaving with a woman election officer.

## LOSE-LOSE

It is Congress policy to not name chief ministerial candidates before elections. "Elected MLAs will decide" is the refrain but in Rajasthan the tactic could be suicidal. **Ashok Gehlot** has been given a large chunk of seats to his supporters, hoping to encash the cheque if the Congress wins. The powerful Jat lobby is not amused and retribution may not be far off even if the Congress wins.

by Rohit Parihar

THE ONCE AND  
HOPEFUL CHIEF  
MINISTER ASHOK  
GEHLOT



PURUSHOTTAM DINAKAR